

a brighter eye area, reduced lines and wrinkles, and pigmentation reduction.

Sansanwal suggests performing facial exercises four to six times a week, around 15 minutes every day, for at least six weeks to see the benefits. “The techniques are designed to soften and relax your facial muscles. In order to achieve results and symmetry, we need consistent practice in the right sequence,” she says.

For a total face workout, she recommends practising exercises such as the ‘cat eye’, which concentrates on the upper part of the face and helps reduce dark circles and wrinkles around the eyes; ‘eye caterpillar’ that helps in lifting the brow up; ‘total face lift’ that rejuvenates, lifts, and tones all 57 muscles on the face and neck; ‘air kisses’ to burn jaw fat; and ‘swan neck’ for toning the jaw and tightening the neck.

The other benefit of face yoga is that you can do it anywhere, at any time. Whether stuck in traffic or waiting in queue, you can always blow out your cheeks, tap your face with your fingers, or massage your eyebrows. Yes, you may get a few strange looks from passersby, but that’s a small price to pay for healthier skin.

So, does face yoga really work? There don’t seem to be too many scientific studies to back it up. Maybe it’s just something that hasn’t

been studied enough. In 2018, dermatologists at Northwestern University published a paper according to which women who practiced face yoga exercises for 20 weeks were perceived to look up to three years younger. But that is not to say that face yoga is only for women. “Face yoga is a series of exercises that tone and strengthen the muscles on your face, just like workouts tone your body’s muscles. Men have facial muscles too, so why should they miss out on the benefits of face yoga?” asks Sansanwal, who teaches several men.

However, dermatologists warn that those with acne-prone or sensitive skin should be wary of the trend, as touching or pulling the skin could worsen its condition.

While the jury is still out on the long-term benefits of face yoga, there doesn’t seem to be any harm in practising it. So, if you enjoy doing it, go ahead. As for me, my favourite exercise is to look towards the sky and blow kisses out to the universe. I’m not sure how much benefit my facial and neck muscles gain but it surely makes

my soul happier. And that’s definitely a stress buster. **BT**

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